

TURNING OFF THE TAP

To control the Rs 7,000-crore flood of donations every year, the Home Ministry bans 44 NGOs from receiving foreign funds, part of which may be fuelling terror. A new law is in the making.



TERROR FILES: After the Jamia Nagar incident, the Government has begun scrutiny of all fund recipients

RAVI S SAHANI

■ **By Bhavna Vij-Aurora**

The Government may be dithering on a stringent anti-terror law, but it has taken an aggressive stance to turn off the tap on foreign funds that fuel terrorism in India. The Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA), which monitors foreign funds being received by over 32,000 registered non-governmental organisations (NGOs), has clamped down on the erring and dubious ones from the bunch.

To begin with, it has quietly started "religion profiling" of the organisations to keep a close watch on their activities. In a bid to not appear anti-minority, Home Minister Shivraj Patil has directed officials of the Foreigners' Division to segregate all religious organisations—Hindu, Mus-

lim and Christian. The ministry wants to ensure that the Rs 7,000 crore that comes into the country officially as charity is not used for anti-national purposes, including terror-funding.

In a swift move that cuts across religious and regional barriers, the Home Ministry has also banned 44 organisations, from receiving funds for life. These include several outfits which claimed to be working in the religious and social sectors. Among them: Saraswati Charitable Trust, Delhi; Association Madras Church of Christ, Chennai; Jameah Rashidiyah Trust, Surat; Islamiya College, Kozhikode; Jammu and Kashmir Muslim Conference, Srinagar; and Jamai Atul Falah, Azamgarh.

There are 11 other associations whose accounts have been frozen. "It

would not be right to pick out organisations only of a particular religion. Many Islamic organisations have been under the scanner for long due to the apprehension that they may be diverting their funds for spreading terror," a senior home ministry official said. Several Christian organisations, which have been the biggest recipients of foreign funds over the last few years, are also under close watch. "We have got complaints about many organisations that are diverting funds to be used for conversion," the official said, adding that many Hindu organisations are also on the watchlist. Some of the organisations which receive large amounts of foreign funds are the Chennai-based World Vision of India, and Caritas India and Churches Auxiliary for Social Action, both head-